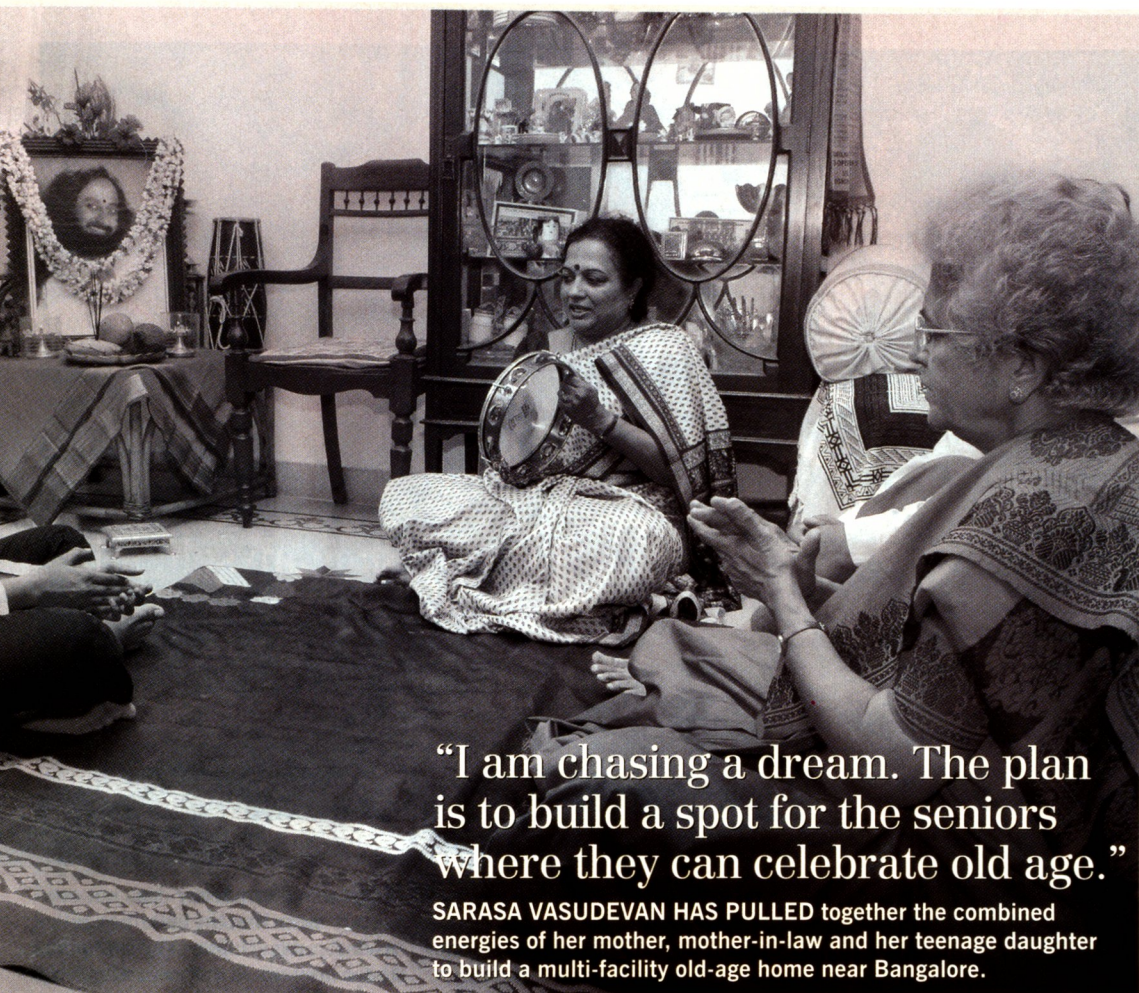




"I am chasing a dream. The plan is to build a spot for the seniors where they can celebrate old age."

SARASA VASUDEVAN HAS PULLED together the combined energies of her mother, mother-in-law and her teenage daughter to build a multi-facility old-age home near Bangalore.

senior citizens living alone. Delhi and Kolkata have launched police verification schemes for domestic help in right earnest. In Chennai, the police have revived bicycle patrolling in the evenings, while in Pune they are dropping by once a week to lend the elderly an empathetic ear.

"We are getting increasing reports of neglect and abuse of the old," says Mathew Cherian, CEO, HelpAge India. The helpline it runs get hundreds of calls from seniors suffering serious neglect or seeking relief from abusive children. "Often they report that children have turned against them once family property has been signed over," Cherian says. Families where everyone works lock up Alzheimer's patients and leave for the day, he says, lest they get lost. Neighbours sometimes call in to

report about well-dressed old people suddenly living in the neighbourhood park after being tossed out of home.

Take the case of a 70-year-old widower in Delhi. A retired government servant, he is economically self-reliant with his budding homeopathy practice. He owns the flat where he lives with his only son and his family. Still he has to wait endlessly for meals, which rarely suit his age, taste or timings. If he complains, it creates disharmony without serving any purpose. If he comments on any household issue, he is told to mind his own business. In disgust, he has asked his son to leave the house, but to no avail. The WHO report says, it upsets parents to admit to 'abuse'.

Failing health is the other major concern that now-generation worries over. Soon after her father passed away

in March 2006, it became clear to Neelam Rallan of Mumbai that her mother, Satyavati Suri, 86, would need a new home. Ever since the family migrated from Lahore in 1944, Delhi was home—even during those difficult years when her husband was ailing. But being alone is just not an option: Suri is losing her vision. The Census shows that one out of every two elderly suffers from at least one chronic disease that requires lifelong medication. Check out the range: nearly 50 per cent report arthritis, 40 per cent hypertension, 30 per cent hearing impairment, 40 per cent defective vision, 10 per cent diabetes; 89 out of every 1,000 are mentally ill (No wonder, cases of suicide among the elderly living alone are reported so often). "In developed countries, utilisation of healthcare by elders